to vital expertise and support networks, ensuring that the value of staying engaged is evident not just to leaders but to the broader public.

INSTITUTIONAL CONCESSIONS

IOs often find themselves in the crosshairs of populist leaders who perceive them as bastions of global elitism that constrain national sovereignty. These tensions are rooted in historical imbalances, as many long-standing IOs were designed in the aftermath of World War II, heavily influenced by Western powers like the United States, the UK, and France. Over time, emerging powers such as Brazil, India, and China have grown increasingly frustrated with their limited representation in institutions like the World Bank, IMF, and UN (Pratt 2021). Meanwhile, smaller states often criticize these IOs as tools of neocolonialism that impose liberal norms at the expense of sovereignty (Voeten 2020). These grievances are fertile ground for populist leaders, who amplify such discontent by framing IOs as elitist and detached from the interests of ordinary citizens.

One avenue to address these underlying tensions is for IOs to redistribute voting power and leadership roles more equitably among member states. This would involve reducing the disproportionate influence of the United States and its wealthy allies and increasing representation for middle- and low-income countries, including rising powers like China (Kaya 2015). Greater voice and influence within IOs would allow these countries to align institutional policies with their foreign policy goals, reducing the temptation to exit or disengage.

IOs could also address perceptions of elitism by adjusting their hiring practices and increasing transparency. Many IOs are staffed by individuals from Western countries, often with advanced degrees from prestigious institutions (Weaver 2008; Nelson 2017). These technocrats make decisions through opaque processes, presenting outcomes as inevitable while leaving little room for public input or dissent. This dynamic fuels resentment, as individuals who disagree with these policies have no opportunity to hold international bureaucrats accountable at the ballot box (Zürn 2022).

To counter this, IOs could diversify their leadership and staff to include more representatives from non-Western and developing countries. Diverse bureaucracies tend to be perceived as more legitimate, particularly among